



FOSS Bytes

Athlon II X4 620 & 630—Quad-Core for Mainstream

With the recent introduction of Intel's new LGA 1156-based Core i5 and Core i7 processors, AMD faces even more pressure in the competitive upper-mainstream and high-end market segments. Phenom II is a great processor design, but it can only beat Intel's growing Nehalem family on price.

The new Athlon really isn't new, although AMD introduces two fresh core names for it: Propus (for the quad-core family) and Rana (for the triple-core).

Propus is a 2.6 GHz processor that's blessed with all the features of the Phenom II, including its 45 nm SOI manufacturing process and four cores with 512 KB L2 cache each. The chip also sports all of the extensions you'd want today: MMX, SSE, SSE2, SSE3, SSE4a, Enhanced 3DNow!, the NX bit feature (or execute disable, on Intel CPUs), 64-bit support, AMD-V virtualisation support, and Cool'n'Quiet to lower clock speeds and voltages during idle periods.

Since Propus is based on the Deneb design, all new Athlon II X3 and X4 processors can operate either on Socket AM2+ platforms with DDR2 memory or on Socket AM3 with DDR3. Clearly, the new processors represent an excellent upgrade option for older AM2 systems, especially if you consider the attractive \$100 price point.

Given this, the Athlon II X4 breaks with AMD's tradition of implementing shared cache memory in unified multi-core processor designs. The L3 omission is the main differentiator between the Phenom II and the Athlon II families, although there are obviously also clock speed differences. One thing about these two platforms that you always need to consider is whether the system is going to last. How easily is it upgradable? Well, with the AMD platform you can easily upgrade the processor to a Phenom II and the RAM is already DDR3.



Palm drops Windows Mobile for webOS

Palm Inc has announced that it is going to stop making devices based on Microsoft's Windows Mobile, and will instead focus entirely on webOS-based smartphones like the Palm Pre.

For several years, this company followed a multi-OS strategy, offering models based on either Microsoft's Windows

Mobile or the Palm OS, which was recently replaced by the webOS. But no longer.

Jon Rubinstein, Palm's CEO, has announced, "Due to the importance of webOS to our overall strategy, we've made the decision to dedicate all future development resources to the evolution of webOS. Which means that going forward, our roadmap will include only Palm webOS-based devices."

Motoblur—the latest Android-based social media monster

In their bid to customise the open source operating system, Android and Motorola have come up with a completely different UI, christened Motoblur. It is interesting to note how much social media has affected today's mobile interface designs, living proof being the Nokia N97, HTC Hero and Motorola Cliq.

As you can see from the image alongside, the home screen looks like a very cluttered version of the Nokia N97 but has been heavily inspired by today's social networking needs. Some very interesting interface changes we found are:

- There are tons of social networking widgets. Be it FaceBook, MySpace, Twitter or Flickr, the OS has it all.
- The integration with the social networks is what blows your mind. One can check out updates of any contact, from all the social networks (supported) right in one single window. This had been a very useful feature of the BlackBerry OS 4.5+. I guess, it's time some one else took up the mantle too.
- All kinds of updates, notifications and messages have been streamlined into one single inbox, be it the SMSs, e-mails or social network updates.
- Getting a call? See the caller's latest Facebook/Twitter profile photo and Facebook status pop-up as the caller ID. Tap on a contact and see the person's entire social network history right

within the address book. It's a very comprehensive take on all your social networks.

- The phone (Motorola Cliq) is also equipped with a 5 MP camera, enough resolution for any social media enthusiast to keep sharing pictures within the network.

